THE AMERICAN REVOLUTIONARY WAR

THE REVOLT OF 13 North American colonies in 1775 led to war with Britain and the founding of the United States. The American rebels created a Continental Navy that lacked the resources to challenge the might of the Royal Navy, but did found a naval tradition. Its most significant action was the lake battle at Valcour Island in 1776, which at heavy cost delayed a British advance from Canada. Raiding and harrying actions by enterprising captains such as John Paul Jones raised spirits but had limited effect. Major naval conflict developed only when France, Spain, and the Dutch Republic entered the war against Britain. Battles were then fought in the West Indies, in European waters, and in the Indian Ocean, as well as off the United States. In the end naval power was crucial, for the British army in North America was dependent on supply by sea. The French victory at Chesapeake Bay in 1781 caused the surrender of the British at Yorktown and hence American triumph in the war. Yet Admiral Rodney's tactically innovative victory at the battle of the Saints was a reminder that the era of British naval dominance was very far from over.



Engagement on Lake Champlain
British ships fire broadsides at the American line in a firefight lasting several hours. The American squadron was largely destroyed, but the battle did successfully delay the British advance.

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VALCOUR ISLAND



Date October 11–13, 1776
Forces British: 30 ships; Americans: 16 ships
Losses British: 3 gunboats; Americans: 11 ships

Location Lake Champlain, New York

By the summer of 1776 the British had repulsed an American invasion of Canada and planned to counterattack by taking troops across Lake Champlain to the Hudson. A naval race began, with the Americans under Benedict Arnold improvising a naval squadron on the southern shore of the lake while the British did the same in the north.

The two forces met on October 11. The British, commanded by Captain Thomas Pringle, had the three-masted 18-gun *Inflexible*, the schooners *Maria* and *Carleton*, plus an array of small gunboats and other craft. Arnold had a force of about half the size including three schooners and a sloop, plus row galleys and gondolas built on the spot. Hoping to avoid the need to maneuver with his inexperienced crews, Arnold anchored the American squadron in a line across the channel between Valcour Island and the shore.

The battle started badly for the Americans when their schooner *Royal Savage* ran onto rocks, but the *Carleton*, advancing to board the disabled ship, was itself battered by the concentrated fire of the American line. With half her crew and her captain killed, the *Carleton* made a fighting withdrawal under the command of 19-year-old midshipman Edward Pellew—a future admiral. The Royal Navy's small gunboats bore the brunt of the fighting. The Americans sank one and disabled two others, but themselves took heavy punishment.

By nightfall the gondola *Philadelphia* was sinking and the British expected to finish off the rest of the American ships the following day. During the night, however, the Americans slipped away undetected. The British gave chase and overhauled the more damaged American ships. One was sunk, one captured, and others deliberately run aground. Five vessels reached the fort at Crown Point, though these were eventually burned to keep them out of British hands.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

TURTLE SUBMERSIBLE

American patriot David Bushnell (1742–1824) of Saybrook, Connecticut, devised a submersible vessel to counter the Royal Navy's coastal blockade. His egg-shaped *Turtle* had ballast water tanks that were filled to make it dive, then emptied with a hand pump to return to the surface. It carried an underwater gunpowder charge to be attached to the hull of a ship at anchor and detonated by a time fuse. The *Turtle* went into action on September 7, 1776, with volunteer Sergeant Ezra Lee at the controls. It was launched into New York Harbor to attack the British flagship, HMS *Eagle*. Lee brought the *Turtle* up against the underside of *Eagle's* hull undetected, but failed to attach the explosive charge to the ship's copper-sheathed bottom. The *Turtle* made three attempts to sink British ships but never achieved a successful attack.



Revolutionary submersible
Seated in the cramped interior, the operator maneuvered the *Turtle* underwater using screw propellers, operated by foot pedals and a handle.